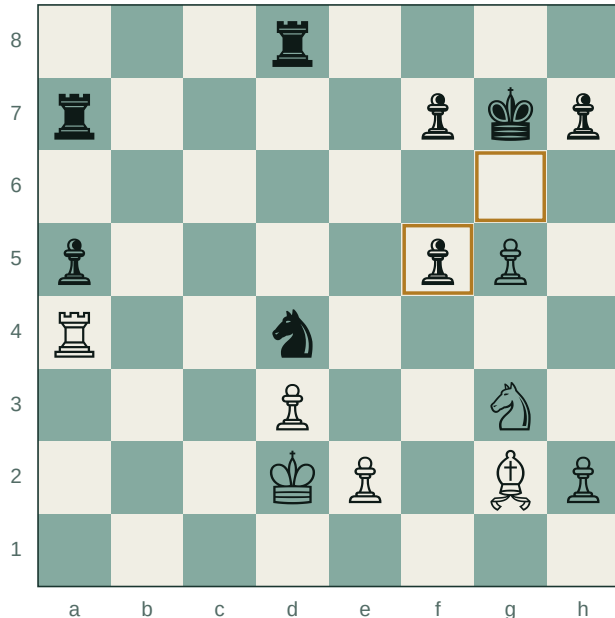


Capture the defender: White, move 33

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 32...gxf5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

33. Rxd4 Rxd4 34. Nxf5+ Kg6 35. Nxd4

33.Rxd4 The rook captures the knight on d4. Recorded reply: **33...Rxd4**.

34.Nxf5+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From f5 it attacks king on g7 and rook on d4. Recorded reply: **34...Kg6**.

35.Nxd4 The knight captures the rook on d4.

At the end, nominal material is White 10 / Black 8 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from -2 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g7. Geometrically undefended: rook on d8 and rook on a7. Check for tactical protection.